

Hackathon Participant Guide

Over three days, you'll build something from scratch, demo it, and compete for the win.

What This Is

A three-round hackathon where you build whatever you want within a challenge theme. Demo it, and see who wins.

One team takes the top prize. Runner-ups get recognition.

The Three Rounds

Round 1: Kickoff & Start Building

Duration: Up to 2 hours

- Form your team (solo, pairs, or groups of 3)
- Challenge theme gets announced
- Rules and requirements explained
- Start building

By the end: You should have a clear idea of what you're building and started working on it.

Round 2: Build Sprint

Duration: Up to 2 hours

- Quick progress check-ins (show what you've got so far)
- Focused build time with support available
- Possible twist or additional requirement announced
- Keep shipping

By the end: Your project should be taking shape. Core functionality should be there or close.

Round 3: Submission & Demos

Duration: Up to 2 hours

- First hour: Submit your project and Git repository for review. Organizers will review codebases and commit history during this time.
- Second hour: Demo time (5 minutes per team), voting by judges, winner announced and awards given

By the end: One winner. Shields and medals distributed.

Between Rounds

You can (and should) work on your project outside the official rounds. Think of the rounds as checkpoints and structured time, the real building happens whenever you make time for it between Round 1 and Round 3.

The teams that put in work between sessions will have noticeably better projects.

Rules & Requirements

Team Formation

- Solo, pairs, or teams of 3 people maximum
- Form teams during Round 1 or bring your own
- Can't switch teams after Round 1

What You're Building

- Must start fresh in Round 1 (no pre-built projects)
- Any format: web app, mobile app, CLI tool, bot, browser extension, API, game, whatever works
- Must be demonstrable in Round 3

- All work must be your team's
- **Must maintain a Git repository with proper commit history.**
 - *This is how we verify the work is yours and track your progress. Initialize your repo in Round 1 and commit regularly as you build. No single massive commits with everything, your commits should show incremental progress. (read more in: FAQ below)*

What's Allowed

- AI coding tools (ChatGPT, Claude, GitHub Copilot, whatever)
- External libraries, frameworks, APIs
- Internet for research and documentation
- Asking organizers for help

What's Not Allowed

- Starting before Round 1
- Submitting pre-existing projects
- Copy-pasting entire codebases from others
- Switching teams after Round 1

The Challenge

[Will be announced in Round 1]

The theme will be specific enough to give you direction but open enough for creativity. Could be anything from "build something useless but impressive" to "make something that shouldn't exist but absolutely should."

You'll find out in Round 1. Then you build.

Judging & Winning

How Projects Are Judged

After all demos in Round 3, judges vote based on:

1. **Does it work?** - Can you demo it without it falling apart?
2. **Is it interesting?** - Creative concept or actually solves something?
3. **How well did you execute?** - Quality, polish, attention to detail given the time constraints

No credit for slides, pitches, or future promises.

Awards

Two teams will be recognized:

Winner - Top project overall

Runner-up - Second place

Both teams get shields/medals and recognition at the closing ceremony.

Demo Format (Round 3)

Each team gets **5 minutes total**:

- 3-4 minutes: Live demo of what you built
- 1-2 minutes: Brief explanation of what it does and why you built it

Important:

- **Submit your Git repository link in the first hour of Round 3** - organizers will review your codebase and commit history during this time. Demos happen in the second hour.
- Live demos preferred (show it actually working)
- No slides or pitch decks needed
- If it might crash, have a backup (recording, screenshots, local version)
- Keep it moving - you'll be cut off at 5 minutes

Judges vote immediately after all demos finish. Winner announced right after.

What to Bring

Essential

- Laptop (charged + bring charger)
- Internet AP (4G/5G Device)
- Development environment already set up
- Git installed and configured (you'll need this for version control)
- GitHub/GitLab/Bitbucket account (or any Git hosting platform)
- Any other accounts you'll need (hosting platforms, API keys, etc.)

Tips for Success

Start small and simple. Get a basic working version first. Add features only if you have time. A finished simple project beats an unfinished complex one.

Your demo is everything. If it doesn't work during the demo, it doesn't matter how good your code is. Test your demo multiple times.

Work between rounds. The 2-hour sessions aren't enough to build something great. The winning teams will be the ones putting in work outside the official rounds.

Don't overthink the idea. Pick something achievable and get started. You can always pivot if needed, but only in Round 1.

Ask for help when stuck. Organizers are there to help you ship something. Don't waste hours being stuck on something fixable.

Focus on the core feature. Build one thing that works really well rather than five things that half-work.

FAQ

I've never done a hackathon before. Will I be okay?

Yes. Just build something, get it working, and show it. That's the whole thing. Plenty of people are in the same boat.

I don't know how to use Git. Am I screwed?

No. Git is required, but if you don't know the commands, ask AI tools for help (ChatGPT/Claude can walk you through basic git commands). You need to know what Git is conceptually, but you can learn the commands on the fly. Basic workflow: `git init`, `git add .`, `git commit -m "message"`, `git push`. That's most of what you need.

What's a "sane" commit history?

Commits should show incremental progress. Not one giant commit with everything at the end. We should see you building over time: initial setup, adding features, fixing bugs, etc. If your entire project is one commit, that's a red flag.

Can I participate solo?

Absolutely. Solo means less coordination and you move at your own pace.

What if I don't know what to build?

Wait for the theme announcement in Round 1. It'll give you direction.

Can I use no-code tools?

If you can demo a working project, use whatever tools you want.

What if my project breaks during the demo?

Have a backup plan ready. Screen recording, screenshots, or a stable local version. Something to show what you built even if the live version fails.

Can I change my idea mid-way?

Yes, but don't do this after Round 1 unless your current project is completely dead. You'll waste time. Finishing something beats starting over.

Do I need to deploy/host my project?

Not required, but it helps. If running locally, make absolutely sure it works on your laptop during demo time.

What if I can't attend all three rounds?

You need to be there for Round 1 (team formation and kickoff) and Round 3 (demo and judging). Missing Round 2 isn't ideal but you can work on your own.

Technical Notes

- Bring your development environment ready to go (don't waste Round 1 installing things)
 - **Git is mandatory** - Initialize your repo in Round 1, commit regularly throughout. We check commit history to verify work is yours and done during the hackathon.
 - If using external APIs, have your keys and accounts set up beforehand
 - Test your demo on the actual laptop you'll be presenting with
 - WiFi will be available but don't rely on it for critical functionality
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Contact

Questions during the event? Find the hackathon organizers at the venue during rounds.